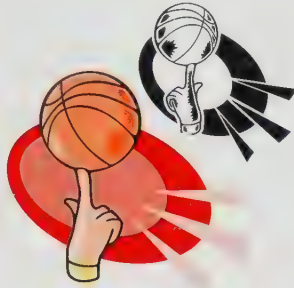


themselves without causing property damage or personal injury. What I like most about these types of parties is that the kids are occupied but still have plenty of chances to socialize.

Consider all the costs (money and time). I have finally realized that there are many components to party planning and each has a dimension of time and cost to consider:

- Venue
- Activities
- Food
- Decorations
- Treat bags

Having a party at home can be the most frugal option or can cost you plenty, depending on your choice of activity or entertainment, extravagance or absence of decorations, food, and treat bags or party favors. For me, getting my house and yard in shape for guests is often a time-consuming challenge, though others may have spotless, ready-to-have-a-party homes. Decorations for a themed party can be pricey, so learn from my mistake, and make sure that the money you save on having a party at home isn't diverted to paper goods, Mylar balloons, and trinkets with images of fictional characters.



Other free or very inexpensive options include reserving space at a local park, the clubhouse in your neighborhood, or even your place of worship. Check rental fees and reservation requirements well ahead of the big day: The baseball field at a nearby park cost just \$10 but it could only be reserved a few days in advance (also, don't assume that public spaces are cheap: some sites can run \$100 or more).

It's obvious that if you hold a party on a baseball field, then you'll play baseball or perhaps softball or kickball; skate at the skating rink; bowl at the bowling lanes; swim at the swimming pool. But you might rent space at a public facility and arrange for entertainment and activities, in which case your time and cash expenditures increase.

Evaluate the package deal. You might decide to pay a fee (or a series of fees) for a party package or menu of services. Most price lists are very specific about what is provided. Still, a busy parent might not notice that the goody bags provided by the bowling lanes are empty or that party guests will most likely share space with shoppers at the Build-A-Bear Workshop.